

The French Revolution (1789 – 1799)

Bottom Line:

The **French Revolution** was a major political and social upheaval in **France** that dismantled the monarchy, ended feudal privileges, and laid the foundations for modern democratic principles such as citizenship, equality before law, and popular sovereignty.

1. Background and Causes

The revolution emerged from a combination of economic crisis, social inequality, and political conflict.

Key Structural Causes

- **Economic Crisis**
 - Heavy national debt from wars and royal spending
 - Rising food prices and grain shortages
 - **Social Inequality**
 - Privileged clergy and nobility paid little tax
 - Common people carried most of the tax burden
 - **Political Discontent**
 - Absolute monarchy under **Louis XVI**
 - Lack of representation for the majority population
 - **Influence of Enlightenment**
 - Philosophers such as **Jean-Jacques Rousseau** and **Voltaire** promoted ideas of liberty and popular sovereignty.
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2. The Three Estates of France

French society was divided into three estates with unequal rights and privileges.

Estate	Social Group	Approx. Population	Privileges
First Estate	Clergy	~0.5%	Tax exemptions, church authority
Second Estate	Nobility	~1.5%	Feudal privileges, land ownership
Third Estate	Common people (peasants, workers, bourgeoisie)	~98%	Paid most taxes, little political power

Key Point:

The Third Estate carried the economic burden but had minimal political influence.

3. Major Events of the Revolution

Timeline of Important Events

Year	Event	Significance
1789	Storming of the Bastille	Symbolic start of the revolution
1789	Declaration of the Rights of Man	Introduced equality and civil rights
1792	Monarchy abolished	France became a republic
1793	Execution of Louis XVI	End of royal rule
1793 – 1794	Reign of Terror	Radical phase led by Maximilien Robespierre
1799	Rise of Napoleon Bonaparte	End of the revolutionary government

4. Key Revolutionary Principles

The revolution introduced several political ideas that later influenced democratic systems worldwide.

Core Ideals

- Liberty
- Equality
- Fraternity

Political Changes

- End of feudalism
 - Establishment of constitutional governance
 - Recognition of citizen rights
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5. Outcomes and Global Impact

Immediate Outcomes

- Abolition of feudal privileges
- Redistribution of political power

- Formation of the First French Republic

Long-Term Impact

- Spread of nationalism and democratic ideals
- Inspiration for revolutions in Europe and the Americas
- Rise of **Napoleon Bonaparte** and the Napoleonic era

6. Key Figures

Person	Role
Louis XVI	King whose rule collapsed during the revolution
Marie Antoinette	Queen executed during the revolution
Maximilien Robespierre	Leader during the Reign of Terror
Napoleon Bonaparte	Military leader who eventually took power

7. Summary

The **French Revolution** transformed **France** from an absolute monarchy into a society influenced by democratic ideals. Despite its violence and instability, it reshaped global politics and introduced principles that continue to shape modern governance.
